



Before You Go In

Small cards with things to say to yourself in the ten minutes before an exam, and things to say to a friend who is panicking in the corridor. There is also a slip for a friend who needs an adult. It takes fifteen minutes of tutor time in the week before the first exam to read them through together. Then the cards live in a pocket or a pencil case. What students get is a few sentences ready before they need them, so that the corridor is not the first time they hear them.

Before you start. Exam mornings are when things surface. The slip exists so that a student never has to decide alone whether a friend is fine. When one reaches you, find the student before the paper starts if you can, and pass anything beyond nerves to your safeguarding lead the same day. Tell the form who the slip can go to, including exam staff on the door.

Print these

Page	What it is	How many
Page 2	Eight cards to say to yourself	One sheet per student
Page 3	Eight cards to say to a friend	One sheet per student
Page 4	The slip: this is more than nerves	A few sheets, kept somewhere students can take one

The fifteen minutes

Step	What happens
1	Hand out pages 2 and 3, one of each per student, uncut. Read the “to yourself” cards out loud, one each around the room.
2	Everyone picks the one they would want in their pocket outside the exam hall, and says why to the person next to them.
3	Read the “to a friend” cards the same way. Everyone picks the one they would most want said to them.
4	Show the slip. Say who it goes to, that using it is allowed, and what happens when one arrives. Leave a stack where students can take one without asking.
5	Everyone cuts out their two chosen cards. They go in a pocket, a pencil case or a planner, and that is the whole activity until the corridor.

Worth knowing

- The cards are deliberately not affirmations. Each one is something to do or something true, because a nervous person cannot use a compliment and can use an instruction.
- Keep a few spare sets in a drawer through the exam weeks, and a stack of slips near the door.
- This also works for a driving test, an interview or an audition. The corridor is the same.

New resources go up on thepastoralguide.com as they are made. Leave your email there and you will hear when they do.





In the ten minutes before

Eight cards. Pick the one you would want in your pocket outside the hall, and cut it out.

TO YOURSELF

I do not need to feel ready. I need to start with question one.

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TO YOURSELF

The first minute is the worst. It gets easier once I start the first question.

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TO YOURSELF

One question at a time. The paper does not know how the last one went.

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TO YOURSELF

If my mind goes blank, I write down what I do know and come back to it.

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TO YOURSELF

Breathe out slowly. It is the out breath that slows everything down.

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TO YOURSELF

I am not being compared with anybody in the hall right now. The paper is the only thing in front of me.

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TO YOURSELF

I can leave a question and come back. Blank is not the same as lost.

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TO YOURSELF

Whatever happens in there, I will still be me when it finishes.

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For the friend in the corridor

Eight cards. Pick the one you would most want somebody to say to you, and cut it out.

TO A FRIEND

I am not going anywhere. Breathe with me for a minute.

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TO A FRIEND

You do not have to feel ready. You just have to go in and read the first question.

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TO A FRIEND

Tell me one thing you know. Just one.

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TO A FRIEND

It is normal to feel like this. It goes down once you start writing.

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TO A FRIEND

Whatever happens, I will be outside when it finishes.

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TO A FRIEND

You are allowed to leave a question. Nobody has to answer everything.

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TO A FRIEND

Look at me, not at the door. In through the nose, out through the mouth.

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TO A FRIEND

If this is worse than nerves, we tell a teacher before you go in. That is allowed.

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This is more than nerves

Four to a sheet, cut into quarters. For the friend who is not fine. It goes to any member of staff, before the paper or during it.

THIS IS MORE THAN NERVES

Please could someone check on my friend.

Their name:

Where they are right now:

Which exam, and when it starts:

My name, if I want to give it:

Give this to any teacher or to the staff on the door. You have done the right thing.

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